

A RUSSIAN INTERLUDE
PM Modi and Russian president Vladimir Putin at the Atom Pavilion, VDNkH Exhibition Centre, in Moscow, July 9

India and Russia share decades of close strategic alliance. However, defence sales and military-technical cooperation—one of the pillars of the 'special and privileged strategic partnership'—between the two nations have taken a backseat. In recent years, India has been reducing its reliance on Russian defence equipment and increasingly turning to western allies like the US and France as well as its domestic arms industry to meet its growing needs. This was evident during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's two-day visit to Moscow on July 8 and 9 for the 22nd annual summit between the two nations. In the inaugural bilateral visit of his third term in office, PM Modi held both delegation-level talks and one-on-one discussions with President Vladimir Putin. On the back of bilateral trade reaching an all-time high of $65.70 billion (Rs 55,040 crores) in 2023-24—largely due to India buying large amounts of Russian oil—the focus was on economic aspects. Matters relating to energy, trade, manufacturing, technology and fertilisers were discussed. Announcement of a big defence deal was missing.

The reasons for India's diversification of defence procurement are manifold. There are valid concerns over Moscow's ability to continue delivering spare parts and ammunition for India's large inventory of Russian-origin military platforms when its arms industry is busy supplying materiel for the Ukraine war. Then there is the ongoing boost for India's own defence industry under the government's Make in India initiative, with more indigenous material being inducted than ever before. Finally, the need to partner with the West to counter an aggressive China flexing its muscles in the Indo-Pacific as well as on our northern borders has driven India to diversify its arms imports. India—the world's largest buyer of arms—is reportedly concerned over the quality of some Russian equipment. Indeed, from 76 per cent in the 2009-13 period, Russia's share in India's arms imports dropped to just 36 per cent in the 2019-2023 period, according to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI). Though India expects to spend nearly $100 billion (Rs 83,720 crores) on defence orders over the next decade, it is not contemplating any fresh, big-ticket purchases from Russia.

However, India cannot drastically cut down decades-long close defence/ military ties with Russia. With nearly 65 per cent of Indian hardware being of Russian origin—from tanks, infantry fighting vehicles and multiple rocket launchers to helicopters and fighter jets—spares for such in-service equipment will have to be purchased, especially when Indian troops are in a stand-off with the Chinese military along the Line of Actual Control in eastern Ladakh. Along with this, India would like to follow up on the delivery status of sophisticated equipment like the S400 Triumf surface-to-air missile systems. The India-Russia joint statement at the end of Modi's visit addressed this concern of New Delhi, and said the defence partnership was reorienting to joint research, co-development and production of advanced defence platforms and steps were being taken to expedite delivery of spare parts. There was also mention of joint manufacturing in India of "spare parts and components" under the Make in India programme through transfer of technology. A day before Modi's visit, Russia's state export company Rostec signed an agreement to manufacture advanced armour-piercing 'Mango' tank shells in India for the Russian-built T-90, one of India's main battle tanks.

Then there is the overriding concern about India's main adversary across the Himalayas. As with India's ever-closer military ties with countries like the US and France, one main reason for India's continuing strategic and defence ties with Russia is the growing threat perception from China. India, thus, is walking a diplomatic tightrope between the two camps. This is because of the urgency of dealing with Moscow's ever-growing alliance with Beijing. The China-Pakistan defence partnership, with over 80 per cent of Pakistani arms imports being from China, adds to the